

Standard Operating Procedure

Fall-Risk Assessment and Prevention

«Hospital Name» — Supports COP.16.b (Stop-Work)

SOP No.	[Hospital to define]	Version	1.0
Effective Date	_____	Review Frequency	Annual, or on change
Prepared By	Quality Coordinator Name: _____ Signature: _____		
Approved By	Medical Superintendent Name: _____ Signature: _____		

1. Purpose

This SOP describes how «Hospital Name» identifies patients at risk of falling and puts prevention measures in place, using a validated assessment tool.

2. Scope

Applies to every in-patient at admission and on any significant change in condition.

3. Responsibility

Admitting/Ward Nurse: completes the fall-risk assessment and implements the resulting management plan.

4. Procedure

1. Assess every patient's fall risk at admission, using the hospital's adopted validated tool (e.g. Morse Fall Scale).
2. Document the tool used and the score/risk level — an informal or non-validated judgement does not satisfy this requirement.
3. For patients found at risk, implement management measures per written guidance (e.g. bed alarm, non-slip footwear, hourly rounding, bed in lowest position).
4. Reassess fall risk on any significant change in condition, medication change affecting mobility or alertness, or transfer between units.
5. Communicate fall-risk status at every shift hand-over.

5. Stop-Work Authority

Do not use a non-validated or informal method as a substitute for the adopted fall-risk tool.

Do not leave a patient identified as high fall risk without the defined management measures in place.

Raising a missed or overdue fall-risk assessment is not a disciplinary matter.

6. Records

Supported by Record 3 of the COP.16 Required Records pack: Fall-Risk Assessment Record.

7. Related Documents

- HCO_COP_16_v2_REWRITE_DRAFT — COP.16 policy

8. Review

Reviewed annually, and immediately after any in-patient fall with harm.

9. References

- Morse, J. M., Morse, R. M., & Tylko, S. J. (1989). Development of a scale to identify the fall-prone patient. *Canadian Journal on Aging*, 8(4), 366-377. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0714980800008576> — the original validation of the Morse Fall Scale, the hospital's adopted example tool.